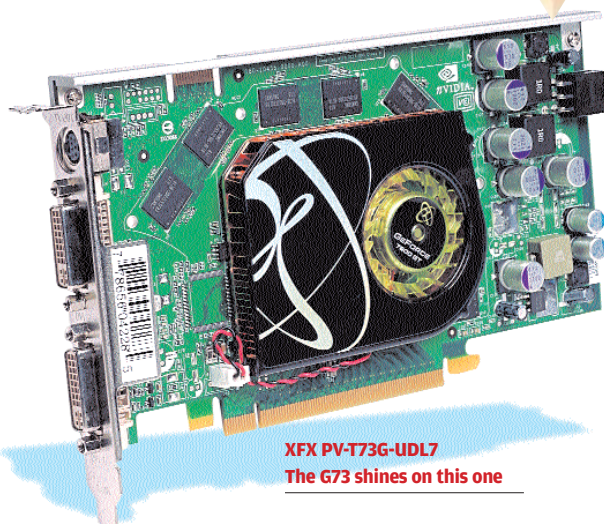


beats the 6800GS chipset, which we feel was a feeble last attempt to prop up NVIDIA's 6xxx family of graphics cards. The 7600GS is identical to its GT counterpart, except for the lower clocks and the use of DDR2 memory (as opposed to DDR3 on the GT). The 6800XT is strictly a mid-range to low-end product, and the scores will prove this fact.

Coming to ATI, the RV 530 (X1600) is another strong-on-paper card. The biggest advantage is the use of 12 pixel pipelines, previously unheard-of on a mid-range GPU, and ATI has added 256-bit memory support for the X1600XT—which was considered high-end not so long ago.

Forsa's 7600GT came with a huge coppery-looking cooler. The other card

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XFX PV-T73G-UDL7
The G73 shines on this one

that had us visually hooked was the MSI 7600GT Diamond. The cooler looks something like the solution on the 7900GTX cards, complete with double-slot design, a full length heatsink and loads of fins—it even has a single heat-pipe! This card was the coolest (thermally as well as visually) in the mid-range group. The most massive heatsink was found bolted onto the ASUS 7600GT Silent. As you've doubtless guessed, no fan on this one—just heat-pipes and lots of fins to dissipate all that heat!

Performance

After firing up the first few cards, we realised two things: first, all the 7600GT cards performed rather similarly, except for the overclocked XFX 7600GT XXX version, which showed an inexplicable drop of frames in *F.E.A.R.* Second, all these cards were faster than the other players in the game (pardon the pun), and ATI's mid-range offerings were left out in the cold! The one exception was ATI's former top-end R480 core, better known as the X850XT Platinum edition. We received one card based on this core—a Powercolor. It performed well, and came close to dethroning the 7600s.

The 7600GT is a real beast in the mid-range segment. Built around a full 12 pixel pipeline design and combining fast GDDR3 memory, the 7600GT brings that "high-performance" feel, well within the range of the budget-oriented buyer.

Despite the high scores, we'd advise you to give the X850 a wide berth. Why? Take a peek at those 3D Mark 06 scores—this is a Shader



I am
my own
network
manager

Jasubhai

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